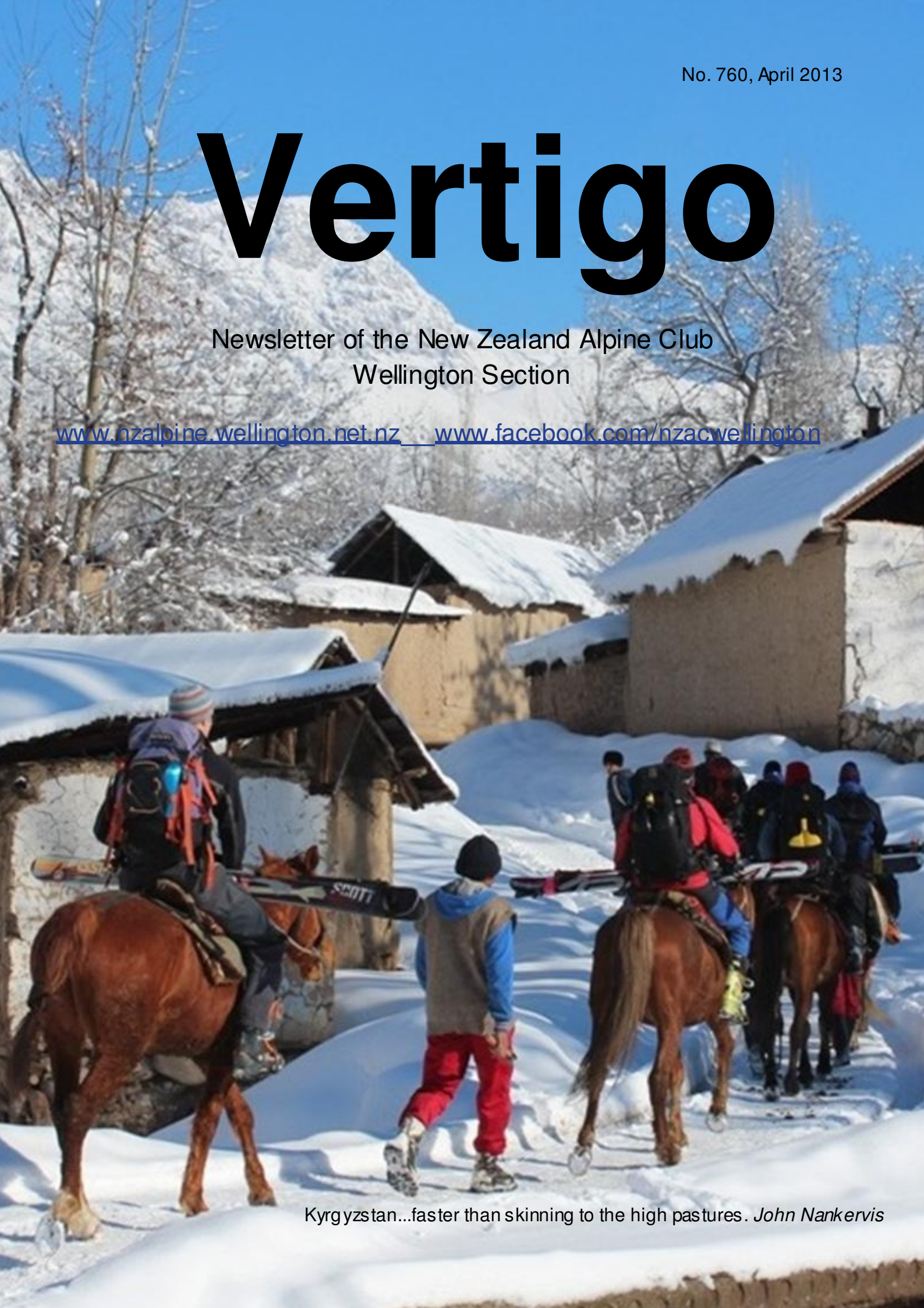


No. 760, April 2013

Vertigo

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club
Wellington Section

www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz www.facebook.com/nzacwellington



Kyrgyzstan...faster than skinning to the high pastures. *John Nankervis*

Next Section Night

Paul Maxim and Geoffroy Lamarche
The Pursuit of First Ascents in Nepal

Monday 8 April, 8 pm

Tararua Tramping Club, 4 Moncrieff St, Mt Victoria, Wellington



Late 2012, a crew of experienced NZAC members were granted permission by the Nepalese Government to attempt two unclimbed peaks near the remote village of Yangma in the Kanchenjunga region in North Eastern Nepal.

John Cocks (Dunedin), Martin Hunter (Auckland), Geoffroy Lamarche and Paul Maxim (Wellington), and Nick Shearer (Oamaru) climbed the East Face of Syao Kang (6041m) from a high camp established below an ice fall.

Paul Maxim and Geoffroy Lamarche share photos and stories of their fantastic adventure!

Club Nights: are at the Tararua Tramping Club clubrooms, on the second Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea & coffee afterwards

Opportunities to get involved!

The club and section depend on the generous volunteering of time and effort from our members. This winter, there are a number of ways for you to get more involved in supporting the activities and other members of our section. Email us at: wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

A unique opportunity presented itself last month when Neelu Memon approached the club looking for support in her special dream. See below.

Winter AIC: following another successful Summer Rock course, the section is preparing for a winter Alpine Instruction Course in July and August. This year's AIC will again be offered under the expert eye of Matt Bennett previously head of training at OPC.

The section and national office have funds to support instructor training and development of suitably experienced climbers who would like to instruct. This is an excellent opportunity to get back into the hills, get up to speed with current best practice, contribute to the section, and a nice pathway to gaining instruction qualifications. Drop us a line if you're interested.

Tukino Lodge working bee 2013 – see below, 19th – 28th April.

Limitless with Support

Wellington woman Neelusha Memon has a dream to become first legally blind woman to climb the seven summits. Neelu and her climbing partner, Tekapo-based mountain guide Gavin Lang, have recently won Hilary Expedition / SPARC support for a January 2014 attempt on Aconcagua, the 6,960m highest peak in America.

To support Neelu we're looking for a special person or persons in Wellington or the Central North Island to play a key role in her preparation this winter.

In 2000, aged 16, Neelu was hospitalized with what she thought was a serious case of the flu. She ended up in a coma as her body battled the illness. She awoke four months later with a brain injury and unable to walk, talk or even swallow. Through rehabilitation and tenacity she recovered these motor-skills but is still disabled in sight and balance.

Neelu has fought back through some serious rehab to cycle at the World Para-cycling Championships in Bordeaux, climb Mount Aspiring, heli-ski the Tasman Glacier, and complete the Coast to Coast in 2012!

This winter Neelu is looking for plenty of time in the mountains, to gain familiarity with gear, terrain and mileage over easy terrain. To make this possible, we're looking for one or two people to take a close supporting role – to be roped to Neelu on these forays.

Ideally these folks would be very experienced in the mountains, be patient and willing to commit several weekends this winter to helping Neelu progress. Please let us know if you are interested, or know of someone who might be. wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or call Dan on 027 768 2185

More on Neelu, Gavin and their Aconcagua trip: <http://hillaryexpeditions.org.nz/?p=822>

Visit Neelu's blog: <http://limitlesswithsupport.weebly.com/>

News and Trip Reports

The Summer Rock course was a hit again this year. The next course will run Jan-Feb 2014. Some reflections on the course from participant Katy Teasdale:

Summer Rock(s) - What's it all About?

Katy Teasdale

Do you take the high road even though it's longer? Do you scramble to the highest point of the cliff to watch the sunset? Is it because it translates to a general ability to transcend the familiar path? Have you looked at a rock face and felt like you could climb it?

Summer Rock starts with an intro which makes you realise there is no 'norm' to the type of person who climbs. Within the group of instructors and students there was no consistent body type, weight, personality type or background.

The opportunity to go away with a friend and some others came up one weekend when I was introduced to the Summer Rock. I decided to do the six week in and outdoor course as I'd, for many years, wanted to learn to climb outdoors. I felt happy to see more of New Zealand (I'm from England and have been here a year), spend weekends in nature, meet lovely people and exercise; stretching and strengthening my body.



We learnt technical skills such as tying knots, preparing gear safely, foot work and holds; learning to top rope and lead climb, to belay and to abseil. We learnt on an indoor wall and then applied those skills on three outdoor trips away.

My first outdoor lead climb was close to petrifying. The base was fine; the holds significant. The top was fine but exposed and a little overhanging. I wanted to be lowered down but was determined to get to the top. I was so relieved to get there I nearly cried! The instructor sitting at the top (in about 25 degrees and in an area called 'Animal Biscuit Valley') said 'I can't decide whether that rock over there looks more like an old man or a dog'. What a relief; the perfect distraction and reminder to take in the view.

To start with not a lot of gear is necessary; a harness and shoes. The rest can come in time. It can be daunting to enter the climbing gym with little experience but you soon realise climbers are a friendly, welcoming crew. One of the instructors, at the end of the course, even professed to be happy to climb with any one of us in the future! You're more of a natural than you think; climbing is primitive and intuitive.



Huge thanks to all instructors this year, especially Scotty Taylor for returning to lead the course, Vincent Zintzen for co-ordination, and Robin Maxwell for catering and cooking!

MacGregor despite them

Rob Roy, Dec 2012. Mark Hooker, Kyle Beggs, Scott Miller.

Scott, Kyle and I settled on Rob Roy Peak as our objective during a brainstorming session at my parents' place in Christchurch. We'd originally been planning a cheeky little mission into the Olivine Ice Plateau from the Dart River to climb Climax Peak but the forecast weather window grew smaller and smaller, so we chose a more accessible objective. Kyle and I were both excited about getting back down into the Aspiring area after many years and Scott had never been there before, so that sealed it.

There are a couple of ways to get up Rob Roy Peak from the West Matukituki side, but we chose the slightly harder West Face route – mainly because of the more interesting approach and the opportunity to stay overnight at the bivy rocks at 1,300 m.

The walk-in up the West Matukituki was pleasant and it didn't take too long to find the old track from Shovel Flat heading straight up the side of the valley. It was lightly but adequately marked until we exited the bush at a slip face. Things got interesting at this point – the "obvious overhang" is actually not visible from below so we exited at the wrong place and faced a long, steep encounter with some of the most hideous alpine scrub any of us had seen. It was definitely the crux of the whole climb. As we hauled, crawled and cursed our way up through the scrub in the hot sun it showed what a good team we were – in fact I don't think there were any sense of humour failures even though we all suffered. This is where you really find out what your friends are like and how well they hold it together. I could see my frustration and anger mirrored in Kyle and Scott's eyes – you just get angry, so angry that you feel like killing something, anything, and I probably would kill something right now if I wasn't exhausted, dehydrated and hanging upside down off a dracophyllum bush...oops sorry, I still have flashbacks.

It was a relief to reach easier tussock slopes, then a stream (water!), and soon after that the biwy rocks. It's an interesting collection of rocks because they all have two or three spots and you need to choose your rock carefully because they all face different directions. Fortunately for us the winds were light and we chose the most comfortable-looking rock with the best view. We went to sleep with views down-valley and the occasional twinkle of light from Aspiring Hut.

The morning found us surprisingly enthusiastic after our scrub-bashing experience the previous day. I think it instilled a kind of bloody-mindedness to make the most of being there since we'd suffered for it already. Apart from some initial route-finding difficulties in the darkness we made fairly quick progress up past the saddle by Pt 1971 onto the large snowfield beyond, and soon we were exploring options for a route up to the summit ridge. Our first impression was that we wouldn't have wanted to be there any later in the season for the climb we had in mind – the "pleasant climb up moderate snow slopes" was halfway to becoming a pleasant rock route up moderate slabs.

Option A was a pair of couloirs at the southern end of the face. Our enthusiasm dimmed when a large chunk of it fell off right in front of us, down the only continuous line. Option B led almost



directly to the summit but appeared to be completely severed by a large schrund with an overhanging uphill face. Option C involved getting right out onto the northwest ridge but closer inspection of the supposedly sound rock showed two chossy steps which didn't look much fun. We had time and decided Option B was worth closer inspection.

To our surprise, there was actually a debris bridge across the schrund so some negotiations ensued as to whether to go ahead with it. In the end, Scott and I crossed the bridge and headed up the face while Kyle stayed behind to take photos. I suspect Kyle decided that climbing with Scott and me was risky enough without me having left the PLB sitting on the kitchen bench back in Christchurch.

The snow was surprisingly firm and I regretted having my bendy old boots. It seemed like an age of climbing a few steps, rest a calf, climb a few steps, rest the other calf – but in the end we got up the face pretty quickly and found ourselves on the beautiful summit ridge views up to the summit, across to Liverpool and Barff, then Aspiring, even Mt Earnslaw in the distance. In a couple of places the ridge divides with a pair of graceful arêtes curving apart to form a small basin and then curving back together again as the ridge steepens.

After shouting “MacGregor despite them” (Rob Roy’s epitaph) from the summit and taking a few photos, we headed back down as we were mindful that Kyle would be sitting at the saddle waiting for us. For those who know me well and are worried that I’ve got this far through the story without mentioning bodily functions, let’s just say that the tourists on the sightseeing plane that buzzed me on the ridge while I was having a moment to myself got their money’s worth.



With a little bit of ropework we were soon back down on the glacier and surprised to find that the snow had turned completely to poo in the two or so hours that we’d been gone – nonetheless, we were soon back with Kyle on the saddle and blasting our way back down the the biwvy rocks with a spring (and gravity assistance) in our steps.

The trip back down through the scrub and bush was a funny one – we sorted out a much better route down through the scrub, but try as we might we couldn’t follow the track down through the bush that we had managed to follow on the way up. In the end we decided it didn’t matter and just bombed down through the bush following the odd animal trail, arriving out at pretty much the right place anyway.

It ended up being a fairly long day so we stayed at Aspiring Hut instead of walking out to the roadend. It was a nice evening and we got to mingle with the climbing groups who had bailed out from Aspiring ahead of the approaching bad weather, as well as the backpacking tourists and families enjoying a short tramp. The hotness of the hut warden played no part in the decision to

stay. We didn't meet any of the local troublemaking keas but if the stories are to be believed, they have learned how to do everything short of carrying out a nuclear test and launching a ballistic missile.

A sprained ankle on the walk out provided the final excuse for not hanging around rock climbing until the weather crapped out, so after filling ourselves with burgers and coffee we tackled the long drive back to Christchurch in holiday traffic. It was great to get back down to the Aspiring area after a long absence and it has stoked my desire and inspiration for some more trips down that way!

Pukerua Bay Revisited

John Palmer filed this report from the field- Spital Field that is. See Wellington Rock for location and other nearby routes grades 12 -24 at Pukerua Bay.

Lacking in quality, quantity and stature, Nobby's Cave (aka the Cave Of Unspeakable Choss) is Wellington's hottest sport crag, (re)developed by Tom Hoyle and John Palmer. And what a crag it is!

With most of Martin Wilson's original grade 24 girdle now part of the foreshore and seabed (if you climbed this route before in a fit of enthusiasm after reading Wellington Rock, you will shudder when you see what became of the crux handrail after the gentlest of taps!), the new version sports better (i.e. still attached) rock and a burly span crux.

But wait there is more. The route now sports a direct start, rising from the back of the cave on often-wet holds. The moves on this are actually pretty good, albeit ever so slightly eliminate. This is called Defrag and goes at around 27. John Palmer claims the credit here, the kind of credit that can lead to bankruptcy.

John also bolted and climbed a variant finish to Defrag, tackling the narrow, horizontal roof at the top of the cave before exiting left just above the previous route. Suspending Disbelief 28 – not just a clever name.

Tom bolted a fierce project on the left wall of the cave, which remains a fierce project despite some fierce attempts. And last but not least, the link-up disease resulted in Nobby's Rave 24, which starts up Nobby's Cave and finishes as for Suspending Disbelief, but sorta more to the right.

Photo topo below provided free of charge (quite a gesture from the developers given the likely level of interest in the crag). If you're thinking of visiting the place, take a helmet and possibly body armour.

Blue: Nobby's Rave (24). As for Nobby's Cave but finish out horizontal roof. Right ledge is in!
Orange: Nobby's Cave (24). Scoot around the cave leftwards. From underclings, big moves lead to a chossy exit.
Green: Suspending Disbelief (28). Defrag variant. From underclings, climb horizontal roof, then back left to small edges. Right ledge out of bounds.

Yellow: Defrag (27). From the back of the cave, climb the vague arête. Avoid anything right of the diagonal crack. Finish up Nobby's Cave.

Red: Pillory 30+ Climb the hanging pillar. Closed project.



Making the most of Waitangi Day

Sabre Peak, Simon Bell and Vaughan Snowden.

Pictures from Sabre made it to the last edition, here's the story from Simon.

Vaughan is a great climbing partner but always forgets something on each trip we go on. I wondered what it would be on this trip. On Tutoko it was his crampons (a tourist saved the day by lending a pair) and on the south face of Douglas it was gas (hint: when it starts getting dark in July, it's minus 7 degrees and falling, and you are still 3 pitches from the summit, a hot drink would come in handy!). I didn't have to wait long to find out what it was this time - his wallet! Luckily I had the cash to sort this one out.

The plan, to make use of Waitangi day and save a day of leave, worked brilliantly! I left Wellington on Monday night after work and on Tuesday we drove to Te Anau from Christchurch. Forgetting that the Milford Road shuts in the evenings meant that we got stranded in Te Anau instead of pushing on to Homer Hut.

Tuesday saw us walking in. We stopped at Gertrude Saddle and chatted to a couple who tented

the night there. On up and over Barrier Knob. This was interesting and I got to try out the trail runners and crampons combination here (we didn't take mountaineering boots for this trip). Adequate, but not ideal, was the terminology used to describe this setup. I've heard there is an option to sidle around Barrier Peak, but this looked uninviting.

After a quick snack on top, we down-climbed to Giffords Crack and completed two 60m abseils to get into the valley. Time constraints meant we traversed the valley high and bypassed the rock bivy. We carried on towards Sabre, traversing through some steep bluffs in the late afternoon (these would have been ugly to ascend or descend in the dark). We found an adequate slightly sloping bivy site on tussock grass and carried on to the base of the route.

Checking out the route the night before proved invaluable. We eventually agreed upon what we were looking at and that evening we completed the first pitch of the 'Direct' start to the north buttress of Sabre. A quick glance at the second pitch convinced us that we could happily tackle this in the morning. Satisfied, we down-climbed the first pitch (rapping was not an option) and left out gear at the base of the route. We then had a leisurely 45 min stroll down to our bivy gear. On the way we passed an excellent bivy site very near to the base of the route - we wished we had lugged our gear up to here, but never mind!

The next morning started as all should, but rarely do, with a good lie in. We skulled back as much water as we could handle, packed 4 litres of water, 2 down jackets and 2 hard shells and many OSMs (one square meals) into a single pack, and hit the rock running. We were on the gentlemen's hour of 9:30am - just as the sun was hitting the buttress!

I quickly repeated the first pitch and moved onto the crux of the climb (pitch two, 19). Even without a pack on, the crack was rather strenuous and while, true to the guide description, the crack 'eats gear', I didn't want to feed it all my cams on the first few metres and have to cut the pitch short. For some reason, I always feel I climb better when I can't see the belayer. When I can see them, it is all too easy to ask them to 'take' - which I did on one occasion. Once they are out of sight, I find you tend to just deal with whatever comes (there is no-one to help or hear your whining after all!). I had the pleasure of leading pitches 3 and 4 too which were still quite challenging and I ended up with terrible rope drag. I had to pull out lots of slack before getting to hard moves to stop the rope friction getting in the way! This also caused me to get pumped from just pulling in the rope for the second climber.

Throughout the day we were surrounded by fog which gave the climb an eerie sensation and spoilt our photo ops!

Vaughan came to the party and led pitches 5 and 6. By now the rock grade had backed down to 14 or so. We simul-climbed pitch 6. From here, it was a scramble to the top. We walked the last part on bare feet as we had had enough of the rock shoes and had left our trail runners at the base of the route.

A quick drink and photo stop on top, and then we started our descent, which comprised down-climbing / scrambling followed by several 60m raps. It was a race between us and nightfall. We go to the col between Sabre and Adelaide Peak with about 30 minutes of daylight free. We then

wrapped halfway down a large snowpatch. I down-climbed the rest of it in rock shoes and used my hands as ice axes. Not ideal! Vaughan took the sensible approach of building a snow bollard and rapping off this. We were very happy to return to the base of the route and get into our trail runners - a 12 hour day in rock shoes or bare feet is not too pleasant (especially if you have rather tight fitting rock shoes like me!).

Our dehydrated and slow brains had a hard time finding the way back to our bivy site. What should have taken 45 mins stretched to double that and I wished I'd GPS recorded the route. Back to camp sometime before midnight and boy did the backcountry taste great!

The following day we walked out and drove back to Te Anau, bypassing the greasy climbers at Homer Hut. We did hear of an ascent of Mitre peak though (something for next year!). Jetstar came to the party with a \$80 flight from Queenstown to Wellington on Saturday, meaning that Vaughan got to drive to Christchurch by himself and I got to attend my climbing partner, Steve Dowall's farewell party that evening in Tawa! I even managed to work on the Sunday, taking my annual leave tally for Sabre back down to two.

Trips

After a fun rock climbing trip To Whanganui Bay 23/24 March we're working on a few ideas for beginner / intermediate level trips for Queens Birthday weekend, mid-winter, and Labour Weekend. Please let us know what trips you'd like to go on, and what trips you'd like to lead!

Notices

New discount for NZAC members

Show Me Shop, in support of the New Zealand Alpine Club, is now offering a special discount code for members only. If you purchase pretty much any item (some sale items excluded), from any category online at www.showmeshop.co.nz and use the discount code at the checkout (alpine2013) you'll receive a 7.5% discount on your purchase/s. In addition, NZAC receives 2.5% of every sale that will go towards the Expedition Capital Fund. So, not only do you get a great discount, your club will benefit as well!

Lenin Peak: Mountaineering Veterans' Festival 2013

Lenin Peak: Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan border

In 2013 the Pamir mountains are waiting for climbers to help celebrate the 85th Anniversary of the first ascent to Lenin Peak, 7134m. The Festival is held within the annual programme of the Union of Asian Alpine Associations. The Kyrgyz Alpine Club are pleased to invite you to join their Veterans Festival to celebrate this event and enjoy various activities - ascent to Lenin Peak, trekking, guided walks etc. Detailed information is available from <http://kac.centralasia.kg/index.php/projects/veterans-festival>

New climber.co.nz Forum for Hut Maintenance, etc

We now have a new forum area to help people keep in touch with each other about hut work-parties, maintenance issues, etc:

<http://climber.co.nz/forum/nzac-huts-lodges>

When establishing a thread, please be very specific for example "Ruapehu Hut" would be too broad, so a thread like "Ruapehu 16 Feb 2013 Working bee" would be more useful. In addition, an initial email to all work-party members to advise them of any thread that involves them specifically, will then establish a central point for all to be kept up-to-date.

Kawakawa Bay PDF download

Kawakawa Bay is on the northern shores of Lake Taupo 5kms west of Kinloch. A great place to go to learn the trade with a mix of trad and bolted routes that will appeal to climbers at all levels. An updated PDF download

is now available online for FREE:

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/donation/kawakawa-bay-pdf-download>

Tukino Lodge Working Bee 2013

Dates: April Friday 19th to Sunday 28th

Dates include ANZAC day and the weekends each side. This will enable people to make a long weekend of it if they want.



Plenty to do no matter what your skills of experience. Some work is heavy, but a lot is light!

Jobs Finish cladding northern wall, cladding upper section western wall – painting these walls. Flashing and painting parts of the roof. **Other outdoor work** Relaying water pipe, general tidy up. **Indoor work** Bunkroom carpentry, painting, finishing drying room ...

Contact: Don French (06) 377 7117 or (027) 445 2980 don.f@xtra.co.nz
TASC on the web tukinoalpinesportsclub.org.nz/

Wellington Section 2012/13 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Email alias*	Phone
Chairperson	Dan Pringle	chairperson	027 768-2185
Vice Chair	Vincent Zintzen	vicechair	
Secretary	Bridget Jarne	secretary or CM2	04 293 6351 (h)
Treasurer	Matt Knarston	treasurer	
National Rep	Dan Pringle		
Patron	John Narkerv is		
Trips	v acant	Trips	
Other Committee Members	Simon Williamson		
	Julian Davidson		
	John Y u		
Other Roles:			
Gear	v acant	gear	
Personal Locator Beacons	v acant	PLB	
Instruction Coordinator	v acant		
Instruction - AIC	v acant		
Instruction - Rock	v acant		
Library	Joke Meerkens	library	
Newsletter Editor	Stev e Minchin	newsletter or SM	
Rock Drill Ov erseer	Kristen Foley	drill or KF	
Website	John Y u	webmaster	
* Email address is: alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz eg. secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz			
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary			
Any media queries should be directed to:			
03 3777 595	National Executiv e Officer	Sam Newton	sam@alpineclub.org.nz



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New pad in 'Da Cave' allowing safe aggressive bouldering

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* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



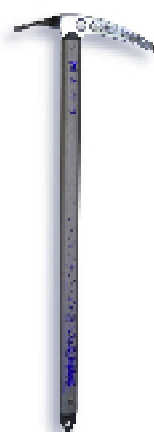
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